





**ALL-STAR SATIRE**
(Clockwise from below) Sohrab Ardeshir and Neil Bhoopalam in *Every Good Boy Deserves Favour*; Denzil Smith in a scene from the play; orchestra playing live on the stage

"When you look at the world at the moment, there are lots of cases where people's personal freedoms and rights are being eroded at a drastic rate," he says. "This play is a warning from history. We live in the age of social media where people express thoughts as quickly as they type, sometimes without thinking. We must realise that a lot of people have suffered and died for that right."

Guthrie also had the 'rare' opportunity to speak and correspond with the 85-year-old Stoppard himself: "You think about the play in a slightly abstract way and then you speak to the guy who dreamt this up, someone who is warm and charming, someone I admire. I had in mind a slightly darker end, but for him, it was different. The best idea in the room sometimes comes from out of the room. In this case, it happens to be from a writer who is a genius."

The play's cast includes Neil Bhoopalam, Denzel Smith, Sohrab Ardeshir, among others. *Every Good Boy...* marks the return of Bhoopalam to the stage after nearly two years. The actor, known for the film *NH10* (2015) and shows like *Four More Shots Please!* (2019—) and *Masaba Masaba* (2020—), says he had to let go of his "TV voice" and get back the "stage one" for this project. Bhoopalam feels that the months-long training he has undergone for this NCPA production will later help his on-camera work: "There's the passion (theatre), and then there's the trade (camera-work). Over there, you get to show off the skill, while here [in theatre], you polish it up. When you are filming, you don't have the luxury to 'slow cook' a part. I love that you can do that in theatre." ■

***Suhani Singh***

includes a combination of plays, music concerts, dance performances, readings, and conversations. **Kunal Kapoor** (left), the director of Prithvi Theatre, mentions that while putting together this edition of the festival, he was particularly inspired by an age-old theatre philosophy—"The stage is never dark." Kapoor, though, by his own admission, remained confident that he wouldn't have to go out of his way to ensure that audiences came back in hordes to Prithvi Festival: "What is amazing is that since the theatre [Prithvi Theatre] opened up to 100 per cent [occupancy], it has experienced a pleasantly surprising average daily attendance of 83 per cent."

In the two years of the pandemic, Prithvi Theatre adapted and held a series of online workshops, the experience of which made Kapoor realise how difficult it is to replicate the physical atmosphere at Prithvi Theatre. To that end, the lineup this year is dedicated to underlining the power of the performing arts. Plays in several languages—Hindi, English, Tibetan, Marathi and Gujarati—have all been included. Writer-director Makarand Deshpande opens the festival by bringing his play *Dat Teri Yeh Grihasthi* to the stage on November 4. That is followed by *Bhoomi* on November 5, noted theatre troupe Adishakti's English stage adaptation of Sara Jospeh's Malayalam play *Bhoomirakshasam*.

Music aficionados can look out for a jazz show by the multi-hyphenate Louis Banks on November 7, and an electrifying closing performance by the musicians of the Symphony Orchestra of India on November 14. Although, for many, the highlight of the festival might be the two sets of poetry readings by veteran actor and theatre personality Naseeruddin Shah on November 13. Kapoor, for one, hopes that people show up in large numbers to celebrate the performing arts because this year's curation feels to him like it is "celebrating the audiences". ■

***Poulomi Das***

This year's Prithvi Festival features a play by Makarand Deshpande and poetry readings by Naseeruddin Shah